A FREE, PLAIN-SPOKEN GUIDE



After a Scam

What to Do in the First 24 Hours, and How to Recover Your Money, Your Identity, and Your Peace of Mind

Banks and cards • Reporting • Credit freezes
Recovery-scam warnings • Healing from shame

D.A. Williams

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What to Do in the First 24 Hours, and How to Recover Your Money, Your Identity, and Your Peace of Mind

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Published by Red Pills of Freedom

Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.

Dedicated to Mom, Janis Fredlund

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This book is for general education. It is not legal, financial, or medical advice. For advice about your own situation, talk to a lawyer, a legal aid office, or a qualified professional. Facts and figures were checked against the sources listed in the Notes at the back of the book as of October 2026. Rules, websites, and phone numbers change. If something looks different when you try it, check the official website named in the book.

The short scenes marked "Example" in this book are made up to show how things usually go. They are not stories about real people.

Contents

INTRODUCTION
It Happened. Now What? 5

CHAPTER 1
The First Hour: Stop the Bleeding 7

CHAPTER 2
Getting Money Back, Payment by Payment 11

CHAPTER 3
Your Rights with Banks and Card Companies 16

CHAPTER 4
Reporting It: FTC, FBI, Police, and More 20

CHAPTER 5
If They Got Your Personal Information 23

CHAPTER 6
Credit Freezes, Fraud Alerts, and Credit Reports 27

CHAPTER 7
Locking Down Your Accounts and Devices 30

CHAPTER 8
The Second Scam: "We Can Get Your Money Back" 33

CHAPTER 9
Shame, Stress, and Getting Your Life Back 36

CHAPTER 10
Helping Someone Else Recover 39

APPENDIX
The One-Page First 24 Hours Checklist 42

RESOURCES
Where to Get Help 43

Notes 46

INTRODUCTION

It Happened. Now What?

If you're reading this because you were just scammed, start here: **you are not stupid, you are not alone, and it is not too late to act.**

You are in very large company. People reported losing $15.9 billion to fraud to the Federal Trade Commission (FTC) in 2025.[1] The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) counted nearly $21 billion in losses reported to it the same year.[2] (These two numbers come from different systems, and some people report to both, so don't add them together.) And most scams are never reported at all.

Those numbers are made of people. Teachers, nurses, engineers, retired police officers, small-business owners. Scammers are professionals who practice their lines every day. Getting fooled by a professional is not a character flaw.

This book is a step-by-step guide for what to do next. It's organized by time:

- **Chapter 1** is the first hour. If money just left your account, go there now.

- **Chapters 2 and 3** explain how to try to get money back, depending on how you paid, and what rights you have.
- **Chapter 4** is about reporting, and why it matters even if you think nothing will happen.
- **Chapters 5 through 7** cover protecting your identity, your credit, and your accounts.
- **Chapter 8** warns you about the "recovery" scammers who come after people who've already lost money.
- **Chapter 9** is about the part nobody talks about: the shame, the stress, and how to heal.
- **Chapter 10** is for family and friends who want to help.

At the back, there's a one-page checklist for the first 24 hours, a list of free help, and Notes with sources for every fact.

One honest word before we start: **some money can't be recovered.** This book won't promise you otherwise, and you should be suspicious of anyone who does. But many people *do* get some or all of their money back, especially when they act fast and pay by credit card or bank transfer. And even when the money is gone, there is a lot you can do to protect yourself from losing more.

Let's begin.

CHAPTER 1

The First Hour: Stop the Bleeding

Speed matters. The FBI says that when you discover a fraudulent transfer, “time is of the essence.”[3] Here’s what to do, in order. Don’t worry about doing it perfectly. Just start.

Step 1: Stop all contact with the scammer

- Don’t answer more calls, texts, or emails from them.
- Don’t send “one last payment” to unlock your money. There is no unlock.
- Don’t confront them or threaten them. Just stop.
- If they had remote control of your computer, disconnect it from the internet right now (unplug the cable or turn off Wi-Fi).

Step 2: Call your bank, card company, or payment service

Use the number on the back of your card, on your statement, or in the official app. Never use a number the scammer gave you.

Say clearly: **“I’ve been the victim of fraud. I need to report a fraudulent transaction and ask you to stop or reverse it.”**

Then ask them to:

- Stop or reverse the payment if they can.
- Freeze or close the account if the scammer has your account details.
- Issue a new card if your card number was shared.
- Tell you what to do next and how to follow up in writing.

Write down the date, time, the name of the person you spoke with, and any case or claim number.

Step 3: If you paid another way, call that company now

Chapter 2 has the details for each payment type. The short list:

- **Gift card:** call the gift card company. Keep the card and receipt.
- **Wire transfer** (Western Union, MoneyGram, Ria): call the company and ask them to reverse it.
- **Payment app** (Venmo, Cash App, PayPal): report it inside the app and ask for a refund.
- **Cryptocurrency or a crypto ATM:** contact the exchange or ATM operator.

- **Cash by mail:** call the U.S. Postal Inspection Service at 1-877-876-2455.

Step 4: Save everything

Don't delete anything, even if you feel embarrassed. Take screenshots or photos of:

- Texts, emails, chat messages, and social media profiles
- Phone numbers that called you (and any numbers they told you to call)
- Websites, usernames, and app names
- Receipts, transaction confirmations, gift card backs, and crypto wallet addresses

This is your evidence. Banks and law enforcement will need it.

Step 5: File with the FBI at ic3.gov

Do this today if money went out by bank transfer or wire. The FBI's Recovery Asset Team works with banks to try to freeze stolen money. In 2025, it acted on 3,900 incidents and helped freeze about $679 million, a success rate the FBI put at 58%.[3] That is not a promise for your case. But it only works if you report quickly, with full transaction details.

> **THE MOST IMPORTANT THING IN THIS CHAPTER:** Call your bank or payment company

first, then report at ic3.gov. The faster you act, the better the odds. Don’t wait until you “know for sure.”

CHAPTER 2

Getting Money Back, Payment by Payment

How you paid makes a huge difference. The FTC keeps a guide for exactly this, called “What To Do if You Were Scammed.” Here’s what it says, payment by payment.[4]

Credit card

1. Report it to the card issuer right away using the number on the back of your card or through the card’s app or website.
2. Ask them to refund your money.

Credit cards usually give you the most protection. See Chapter 3.

Debit card

1. Report it to your bank or credit union right away.
2. Ask them to refund your money.

Federal law protects you from unauthorized use of a debit card, but how much depends on how fast you report it. See Chapter 3.

Zelle or a bank transfer

1. Report it to your bank or credit union immediately.
2. Ask them to reverse the payment and refund your money.

Payment apps (Venmo, Cash App, PayPal)

1. Report it to the payment app immediately.
2. Ask them to reverse the payment and refund your money.

The FTC warns that sending money through a payment app "is like sending cash — it's very hard to get it back."[5] Ask anyway.

Wire transfer

1. Report it to the wire company immediately.
2. Tell them a scammer tricked you into sending money.
3. Ask them to reverse it and refund your money.

The FTC lists these numbers: MoneyGram 1-800-926-9400; Western Union 1-800-448-1492; Ria 1-877-443-1399 (for Walmart2Walmart and Walmart2World transfers, 1-855-355-2144).[6] If you wired money through your bank, call the bank and ask them to recall the wire.

Gift cards

1. Contact the gift card company right away, using the number on the back of the card.
2. Tell them a scammer tricked you into giving them the card number and PIN.
3. Ask for a refund.

Keep the card and receipt. The FTC says some gift card companies might give your money back, and that you should report it no matter how long ago it happened. The FTC keeps a list of contact numbers for major gift card companies.[7]

Cryptocurrency (including crypto ATMs)

1. Contact the exchange or crypto ATM operator immediately.
2. Tell them it was a fraudulent transaction.
3. Ask them to reverse it and refund your money.

The FTC is honest about this one: crypto payments don't have the same legal protections as credit and debit cards, so it can be hard to get money back. But it notes some states have passed laws that might help, and points to the National Conference of State Legislatures to look up your state.[4]

Report crypto losses to ic3.gov too, with the wallet addresses and transaction IDs. The FBI received more

than 181,000 complaints involving cryptocurrency in 2025, with $11.4 billion in reported losses.[3]

Cash sent by mail or delivery service

1. Call the U.S. Postal Inspection Service at 1-877-876-2455 right away. For a fee, it may be able to intercept a domestic package that hasn't been delivered.
2. If you used FedEx or UPS, contact them as soon as possible.[4]

Cash handed to a courier

If you handed cash, gold, or valuables to someone at your door, call your local police right away. It is a crime. Give them every detail you remember: the car, the person's appearance, the time, and the phone numbers used.

What to do if they say no

1. **Ask for the decision in writing,** and ask how to appeal or escalate it.
2. **Follow up in writing yourself.** The FTC recommends sending a letter to confirm what you reported, and keeping copies.[8]
3. **File a complaint with the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB)** at consumerfinance.gov/complaint if your problem is with a bank, credit card,

money transfer service, prepaid card, or virtual currency company. The CFPB sends complaints to the company, and it says most companies respond within 15 days.[9]

CHAPTER 3

Your Rights with Banks and Card Companies

This chapter gives a plain summary of some federal protections. It is general information, not legal advice. Your bank's account agreement and your state's laws may give you more rights.

The big difference: "unauthorized" vs. "authorized"

Federal rules give strong protection when money is taken **without your permission.** For example, someone steals your card number, or a hacker gets into your account and sends money.

Protection is often weaker when **you sent the money yourself,** even if you were tricked. Banks and apps may treat that as a payment you "authorized." That doesn't mean you should give up. The FTC still tells people to report it and ask for a refund.[4] Some banks and payment services do refund scam victims, and some states have their own rules. Always ask, and if the answer is no, ask again in writing and consider a CFPB complaint.

If a scammer got your login, card number, or remote access and moved money *themselves*, say so clearly. That may count as unauthorized.

Credit cards

According to the FTC:[8]

- If you report a lost or stolen card **before** it's used, you aren't responsible for any charges you didn't authorize.
- If you report it **after** someone uses it, the most you might owe is **$50.**
- If someone used your card *number* but the card itself wasn't lost or stolen, you aren't responsible for charges you didn't authorize.

Debit and ATM cards

Debit cards pull money straight from your account, so speed matters more. Here is the FTC's summary of your maximum loss for a lost or stolen debit or ATM card:[8]

If you report it...	Your maximum loss is...
Before any unauthorized charges are made	$0
Within 2 business days after you learn of the loss or theft	$50
More than 2 business days after you learn of it, but within 60 calendar days after your statement is sent	$500

If you report it…	Your maximum loss is…
More than 60 calendar days after your statement is sent	All the money taken, and possibly more (for example, from linked accounts)

The CFPB explains the same rule: if your statement shows an unauthorized withdrawal, notify your bank within 60 days. If you wait longer, you could be responsible for transactions that happen after that 60-day period, if the bank shows they wouldn't have happened had you told them sooner.[10]

If your debit card number was used but the card wasn't lost or stolen, the FTC says you aren't responsible for unauthorized transactions as long as you report within 60 calendar days after the statement is sent.[8]

What to do

1. **Report by phone right away,** then **follow up in writing.** The FTC suggests a letter to the address for billing disputes (credit cards) or errors (debit cards), confirming what you reported, the date, and when you first noticed the problem.[8]
2. **Check every statement** for the next several months, line by line.
3. **Keep a log** of every call: date, time, name, what they said, and any claim number.

4. **If you're not satisfied,** file a complaint at consumerfinance.gov/complaint.[9]

> *Example (made up to show how it works): Maria gets a text that looks like her bank. She clicks, types in her login, and an hour later sees $1,800 sent by Zelle to a stranger. She calls the number on her debit card that night, explains that someone else logged in and sent the money, and gets a claim number. The next day she writes a short letter to the bank's error-resolution address repeating what she reported. She files at ic3.gov and ReportFraud.ftc.gov. Whether she gets the money back will depend on her bank's investigation, but she has done everything she can, quickly and in writing.*

CHAPTER 4

Reporting It: FTC, FBI, Police, and More

Many people don't report scams. They feel embarrassed, or they think nothing will happen. Please report anyway.

Reports help law enforcement find patterns, build cases, and warn others. The FTC says it uses reports to build cases against scammers, spot trends, educate the public, and share data about what's happening in your community.[4] And for bank transfers and wires, a fast FBI report can be part of how money gets frozen (see Chapter 1).

Where to report

1. The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center: ic3.gov. For online and phone fraud, especially if money was sent by wire, bank transfer, or cryptocurrency. The FBI says to file "regardless of the amount lost" and include full transaction details.[3]

2. The Federal Trade Commission: ReportFraud.ftc.gov. For any scam, whether or not you lost money. You can also call 1-877-382-4357.[11]

3. Your local police or sheriff. Especially if you lost money, handed cash to someone, or need a police report for your bank or for identity theft. The CFPB lists this as one of the first steps for scam victims.[9]

4. Your state attorney general. The CFPB suggests this too, and points to the National Association of Attorneys General website (naag.org) to find yours.[9]

5. The company or platform where it happened. The dating app, social media site, marketplace, or payment app. Use its "Report" button.

6. If the victim is an older adult or a person with a disability, the CFPB says to contact local Adult Protective Services. The Eldercare Locator (1-800-677-1116 or eldercare.acl.gov) can help you find the right office.[9]

Special cases:

- **Someone pretending to be Social Security:** oig.ssa.gov/report.[12]
- **Medicare fraud:** 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227).[13]
- **Identity theft:** IdentityTheft.gov (see Chapter 5).

What to include in your report

The FBI suggests including:[14]

- How the person first contacted you and how they identified themselves: name, phone number, email, username, website.

- Payment details: date, type of payment, amount, account numbers, the name and address of the receiving bank, and any cryptocurrency addresses.

Add a short, plain timeline: what happened, in order. You don't need fancy words. "On March 3, a man called saying he was from my bank…" is perfect.

What to expect

Be ready for this: **the FTC and IC3 usually won't call you back about your individual case.** That's normal and it doesn't mean your report was ignored. IdentityTheft.gov's privacy notice says plainly that the FTC does not resolve individual consumer reports; it puts them into a secure database used by law enforcement.[16]

And beware: **the real IC3 will never contact you directly asking for money or information.** The IC3 says it does not work with any non-law-enforcement group, like law firms or crypto services, to recover money.[17] Anyone who calls claiming to be from the IC3 or FBI about your report and asks for a fee is a scammer. More on this in Chapter 8.

CHAPTER 5

If They Got Your Personal Information

Sometimes scammers take more than money. If you gave out your Social Security number, bank login, date of birth, or a copy of your driver's license, you need to protect your identity too.

If you gave out your Social Security number

The FTC's advice depends on whether it's been misused yet:[4]

- **If the scammer used it** (for example, you see new accounts you didn't open): go to **IdentityTheft.gov**, report it, and get a free, personalized recovery plan.
- **If you're not sure whether it's been used:** go to **IdentityTheft.gov/databreach** and follow the steps there.

The IdentityTheft.gov recovery steps

Here's what IdentityTheft.gov says to do right away:[18]

1. **Call the companies where you know fraud happened.** Ask for the fraud department. Explain that someone stole your identity. Ask them to close or freeze the accounts. Change your logins, passwords, and PINs.
2. **Place a free fraud alert** by contacting one of the three credit bureaus. That bureau must tell the other two. Then **get your free credit reports** from Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion at AnnualCreditReport.com or 1-877-322-8228.
3. **Report identity theft to the FTC** at IdentityTheft.gov or 1-877-438-4338. Based on what you enter, the site creates your **FTC Identity Theft Report** and a recovery plan.
4. **You may choose to file a police report** too. Bring a copy of your FTC Identity Theft Report, a photo ID, proof of address, and any proof of the theft.

One important tip: If you create an account on IdentityTheft.gov, the site walks you through each step, tracks your progress, and pre-fills letters. If you don't create an account, you must print and save your report and plan right away, because you won't be able to get back to them later.[18]

Next steps

IdentityTheft.gov's "What To Do Next" steps include closing any new accounts opened in your name and removing bogus charges. For each one, ask the business for a letter confirming the account isn't yours, you aren't liable for it, and it was removed from your credit report. Keep those letters.[18]

Lock down your Social Security account

Social Security suggests that if scammers stole your personal information, you sign in to or create a personal *my* Social Security account at ssa.gov/myaccount. It says this helps prevent identity thieves from opening an account in your name, and that you'll get an alert right away if anyone tries to change your address or direct deposit without your permission.[12]

Protect your tax refund

Identity thieves sometimes file a fake tax return in your name to steal your refund. The IRS offers a free **Identity Protection PIN (IP PIN)**, a six-digit number that stops anyone else from filing a federal tax return using your Social Security number. Anyone with a Social Security number or ITIN who can verify their identity can get one. The fastest way is through your IRS online account at IRS.gov. The IRS will never ask you for your IP PIN; calls, emails, or texts asking for it are scams.[19]

If you gave out your account login

The FTC says:[4]

- **If you can still log in:** create a new, strong password right away (and change it anywhere else you used the same one). Turn on two-factor authentication.
- **If you're locked out:** use the FTC's "How To Get Back Into Your Hacked Account" guide at consumer.ftc.gov, which links to recovery steps for popular services.

CHAPTER 6

Credit Freezes, Fraud Alerts, and Credit Reports

These three free tools are your best protection against someone opening new accounts in your name. Here's what each one does, according to the FTC.[20]

Credit freeze

- **What it does:** While it's in place, nobody can open a new credit account in your name, including you.
- **Cost:** Free to place and free to lift.
- **How long:** Until you lift it.
- **Effect on your score:** None.
- **How:** Contact **all three** credit bureaus: Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion.
- **When you need credit:** You can lift it temporarily. The FTC suggests finding out which bureau a lender will use and lifting the freeze only there, then putting it back.

The FTC says anyone can freeze their credit, any time, even if their identity hasn't been stolen.

Fraud alert

- **Initial fraud alert:** Tells businesses to check with you before opening new credit in your name. Lasts one year, renewable. Free. You only need to contact **one** bureau; it must tell the other two. When you place it, you can get a free copy of your credit report from each bureau.
- **Extended fraud alert:** For people who've experienced identity theft and have an FTC Identity Theft Report or police report. Lasts **seven years**. It also takes you off the bureaus' marketing lists for unsolicited credit and insurance offers for five years.

You can have a freeze *and* a fraud alert at the same time.

Credit bureau contacts

IdentityTheft.gov lists these:[18]

- **Equifax:** Equifax.com/personal/credit-report-services, 1-800-685-1111
- **Experian:** Experian.com/help, 1-888-397-3742
- **TransUnion:** TransUnion.com/credit-help, 1-888-909-8872

Free credit reports, every week

You can check your credit reports from all three bureaus **for free, every week,** at **AnnualCreditReport.com**. The FTC says this weekly access became permanent in 2023,

and that AnnualCreditReport.com is the authorized site.[21]

What to look for: accounts you didn't open, addresses where you've never lived, and "hard inquiries" from lenders you've never contacted. If you find something, go back to IdentityTheft.gov.

What about paid credit monitoring?

Some companies sell credit or identity monitoring. Some people find it useful. But a freeze, fraud alerts, and free weekly credit reports do a lot for free. Be very careful with anyone who contacts *you* to sell "protection" after a scam. The FTC warns about scammers who try to sell "credit card loss protection" by claiming you need it; federal law already protects you from unauthorized credit card use.[8]

CHAPTER 7

Locking Down Your Accounts and Devices

If a scammer had your passwords or got into your computer or phone, take these steps. It's a good idea even if you're not sure.

If they had remote access to your computer or phone

The FTC says:[4]

1. **Update your security software** (or download it if you don't have any; get recommendations from independent review sites, friends, and family).
2. **Run a scan** and delete anything it flags.
3. **Change your passwords** and turn on two-factor authentication.

If you need help finding or removing harmful software, the FTC suggests getting help from the device maker, a company you know and trust, or a knowledgeable friend or relative.[4] Choose that help yourself. Don't use anyone who contacted you.

Change passwords in the right order

Use a device you trust (not the one the scammer accessed, if possible). Change passwords in this order:

1. **Email first.** Whoever controls your email can reset almost every other password.
2. **Banking, credit cards, and payment apps.**
3. **Your phone carrier account.** Add a PIN or passcode if your carrier offers one.
4. **Social media, shopping, and everything else.**

Use a different password for each account. A password manager can help you keep track of them.

Turn on two-factor authentication

Two-factor (or multi-factor) authentication means that logging in takes something besides your password, like a code from a text or app, or your fingerprint or face. The FTC says it makes it harder for scammers to get into your accounts even if they have your username and password.[8]

Never share those codes with anyone. A real bank will never call and ask you to read back a code.

Check for changes the scammer may have made

In your email, bank, and other accounts, look for:

- A new email address or phone number added for recovery
- Email forwarding rules sending your mail to someone else
- New payees or linked accounts in your bank or payment apps
- Devices you don’t recognize that are logged in

Remove anything you didn’t set up.

CHAPTER 8

The Second Scam: “We Can Get Your Money Back”

This chapter may save you more money than any other.

After people lose money to a scam, they’re often contacted by someone who promises to get it back. It might be a “lawyer,” a “crypto recovery firm,” a “government agent,” or someone who says they’re from the FTC, FBI, or a consumer group. They will want a fee first.

It’s another scam.

How it works

The FTC calls refund and recovery scams “the worst of the worst.” It explains that scammers buy and trade lists of people who have already lost money, sometimes called “sucker lists,” and then contact them pretending to be able to recover the money. They ask for a “retainer,” “processing fee,” “tax,” or your bank details “so they can deposit your refund.”[22]

The FBI has warned specifically about fake law firms targeting people who lost money in cryptocurrency scams. Red flags it lists include:[15]

- Claiming to be official partners of U.S. or foreign government agencies. The FBI says no law firms are officially authorized partners of U.S. government agencies.
- Referring to made-up agencies, like an “International Financial Trading Commission.”
- Asking for payment in cryptocurrency or gift cards.
- Knowing the exact amounts and dates of your earlier losses.
- Saying you’re on a “government list of scam victims.”
- Telling you your money is in a foreign bank account and that you need to open an account there or pay “bank fees” to withdraw it.
- Refusing to appear on video or show a law license.

These are not small. In 2025, the FBI received 10,516 complaints about recovery scams, with about $1.4 billion in reported losses (the FBI notes this may include losses from the earlier scams that led people to the recovery contact).[3]

The rules that protect you

- **Law enforcement does not charge victims a fee** to investigate crimes.[14]

- **Government agencies and real organizations will never ask for money** to help you get a refund, and won’t guarantee you’ll get your money back, according to the FTC.[22]
- **The IC3 will never contact you directly** for information or money.[17]
- **Never pay upfront** for help recovering money.[22]
- **Don’t deposit a “refund” check for more than you lost** and send back the difference. The FTC says that’s always a scam; the check will turn out to be fake, and the bank will want the money back from you.[22]

What to do if someone offers to recover your money

1. Don’t give them any money or personal or bank information.
2. Look up the agency or firm yourself. Call a number you found on your own, not one they gave you.
3. If someone claims to be from the FBI, call your local FBI field office to confirm.[14]
4. Report the contact at ReportFraud.ftc.gov, to your state attorney general, and at ic3.gov.[22]

Free, legitimate help exists (see Resources), and it doesn’t come with a fee to unlock your money.

CHAPTER 9

Shame, Stress, and Getting Your Life Back

Losing money is only part of the harm. For many people, the hardest part is how they feel afterward.

You are not imagining it

In a 2015 study for the FINRA Investor Education Foundation, researchers surveyed 600 people who said they had been victims of financial fraud. Nearly two-thirds (65%) reported at least one serious non-financial cost. Half reported severe stress. 38% had trouble sleeping. 35% reported depression. And just under half (47%) blamed themselves for being defrauded.[23]

That study focused on investment and financial fraud, and the people in it chose to take part, so it doesn't tell us how common these feelings are for everyone. But if you're feeling any of these things, you are not weak and you are not alone.

Why it wasn't your fault

Social Security's scam page puts it in five words: "Criminal behavior is not your fault."[12]

Scammers don't win because their victims are foolish. They win because they:

- Practice the same script hundreds of times.
- Pretend to be people you have good reason to trust.
- Create panic or hope so strong that it pushes careful thinking aside.
- Cut you off from the people who might have noticed.

Those are tricks that work on human beings. All human beings.

Things that help

These are general suggestions, not medical advice.

- **Tell someone you trust.** Shame grows in secret. Saying "this happened to me" out loud to one safe person is often the first step.
- **Take action.** Many people feel a bit better once they've done the steps in Chapters 1 through 7. Doing something gives back a sense of control.
- **Join a support group.** AARP runs free, confidential online support groups for fraud victims and their loved ones, led by trained facilitators.[24]

- **Call a helpline.** The AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline (877-908-3360) offers free guidance and support. It does not investigate or recover money.[25]
- **Talk to a counselor or doctor** if you're having trouble sleeping, eating, or getting through the day.
- **Be patient with yourself.** Recovery, money-wise and feelings-wise, takes time.

If you're in crisis

If you're having thoughts of hurting yourself, or feel hopeless, please reach out right now. **Call or text 988**, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. It's free, confidential, and available 24/7.[26] If you're in immediate danger, call 911.

Rebuilding

When you're ready:

- **Make a simple money plan.** If the loss affects your bills, call creditors early and ask about hardship options. A nonprofit credit counselor can help.
- **Set new family rules,** like a code word or a "two-call rule" before sending money. (The first guide in this series, *Protect Your Parents*, has a checklist.)
- **Consider sharing your story** if and when you're ready. People who speak up help others recognize scams. It's your choice, and you never owe anyone your story.

CHAPTER 10

Helping Someone Else Recover

If someone you love was scammed, the way you react in the first conversation matters a great deal.

What to say

- “I’m so sorry this happened to you.”
- “This wasn’t your fault. These people are professionals.”
- “Let’s figure out the next steps together.”

What not to say

- “How could you fall for that?”
- “I told you so.”
- “You should have known better.”

Blame makes people hide the next scam. And scammers often come back to the same victims, especially with recovery offers (Chapter 8).

How to help in practice

1. **Sit with them while they make the calls** in Chapter 1. Let them do the talking if they're able. Banks often need to hear from the account holder.
2. **Help gather evidence** and write a simple timeline.
3. **Help file reports** at ic3.gov and ReportFraud.ftc.gov.
4. **Help with IdentityTheft.gov** and credit freezes if personal information was shared.
5. **Screen for recovery scammers.** Gently remind them: anyone who asks for a fee to get the money back is a scammer.
6. **Watch for signs of depression or hopelessness,** and help them reach support (Chapter 9).

If the person is an older adult or has a disability

If you believe someone is being financially exploited, or if they're still in contact with the scammer and can't seem to stop, contact Adult Protective Services. The Eldercare Locator (1-800-677-1116) can help you find your local office.[9] People 60 and older can also get help from the U.S. Department of Justice's National Elder Fraud Hotline at 1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311).[27]

Respect their independence

Helping doesn't mean taking over. Offer, explain, and ask. Unless a court or a legal document like a power of

attorney gives you authority, the money and decisions belong to them.

APPENDIX

The One-Page First 24 Hours Checklist

Print this page. Free to copy and share.

THE NUMBER ONE RULE: Move fast, and never pay anyone who promises to get your money back.

In the first hour

- ☐ Stop all contact with the scammer.
- ☐ Disconnect any computer they accessed from the internet.
- ☐ Call the bank or card company (number on your card). Say "fraud."
- ☐ Ask them to stop or reverse the payment and secure the account.
- ☐ Gift card? Call the card company. Keep card + receipt.
- ☐ Wire? Call MoneyGram, Western Union, or Ria.
- ☐ Payment app? Report it in the app.
- ☐ Crypto? Contact the exchange or ATM operator.
- ☐ Cash by mail? Postal Inspection Service 1-877-876-2455.
- ☐ Screenshot and save every message, number, and receipt.

In the first day

- ☐ Report at **ic3.gov** (with full transaction details).
- ☐ Report at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov**.
- ☐ File a police report.
- ☐ Follow up with the bank in writing. Keep copies.
- ☐ Change passwords (email first). Turn on two-factor login.
- ☐ Gave out your SSN? Go to **IdentityTheft.gov**.
- ☐ Freeze your credit at Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion.
- ☐ Tell one person you trust.

Call log: Date _____ Company _____ Person _____ Claim # _____

Credit bureaus: Equifax 1-800-685-1111 · Experian 1-888-397-3742 · TransUnion 1-888-909-8872 · Free reports: AnnualCreditReport.com

Not getting help? File a complaint at consumerfinance.gov/complaint.

Help: AARP Fraud Watch **877-908-3360** · Elder Fraud Hotline **1-833-372-8311** · Crisis: **call or text 988**

From After a Scam *by D.A. Williams. Sources are in the book's Notes. Not legal advice.*

RESOURCES

Where to Get Help

All of these were checked in October 2026. Phone numbers and hours can change. Look up any organization's official website yourself. Never use a "help" number that someone contacts you with.

This book is not legal advice. For legal help, contact a lawyer or your local legal aid office.

To report

- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center:** ic3.gov.[3]
- **FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov or 1-877-FTC-HELP (1-877-382-4357).[11]
- **Identity theft:** IdentityTheft.gov or 1-877-438-4338.[18]
- **Problems with a bank, card, money transfer, or crypto company:** consumerfinance.gov/complaint, or call the CFPB at 855-411-2372 (TTY/TDD 855-729-2372), 9 a.m.–6 p.m. Eastern, Monday–Friday.[9]
- **Your state attorney general:** find yours at naag.org.[9]
- **Social Security impersonation:** oig.ssa.gov/report.[12]
- **Medicare fraud:** 1-800-633-4227.[13]

- **Your local police.**

To protect your identity and credit

- **Free weekly credit reports:** AnnualCreditReport.com or 1-877-322-8228.[18]
- **Credit freezes and fraud alerts:** Equifax 1-800-685-1111; Experian 1-888-397-3742; TransUnion 1-888-909-8872.[18]
- **IRS Identity Protection PIN:** IRS.gov (search "IP PIN").[19]

Free support

- **AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline:** 877-908-3360, Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. Eastern.[25]
- **AARP Fraud Victim Support Group:** free online sessions; search "Fraud Victim Support Group" at aarp.org.[24]
- **National Elder Fraud Hotline (age 60+):** 1-833-372-8311.[27]
- **Eldercare Locator / Adult Protective Services:** 1-800-677-1116.[9]
- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline:** call or text 988.[26]
- **Emergency:** 911.

Learn more

- **FTC, "What To Do if You Were Scammed":** consumer.ftc.gov (search the title).[4]
- **FTC, "Refund and Recovery Scams":** consumer.ftc.gov.[22]

Companion guides in this series

Protect Your Parents, *Is That Really Their Voice?*, *Apps That Actually Help*, *Stop Before You Pay*, *When Banks Cheat You*, *Naked Short Selling*, *Disability Benefits Made Simple*, and *Don't Get Doxxed*, all by D.A. Williams and free to share.

Notes

Web addresses were checked in October 2026. Where a source is a report from a government agency, the figures are based on what people reported to that agency; most scams are never reported, so the real numbers are likely higher. FBI and FTC figures come from different reporting systems and should not be added together.

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